Tatemis3D · Game Design Document

Working title · Solo project by Andrés Ruiz Palomino (Arzpal): programming and design

1. Vision and pillars

1.1 Pitch (one line)

A **real-time action creature-collector** with a *How to Train Your Dragon* tone: you don't collect hundreds of monsters, **you bond with a few** and control them fully in combat, combining their unique abilities with **element and environment** to overpower and capture wild beasts.

1.2 The 3 design pillars

1. **Expressive combat, not repetitive combat.** The heart is not attacks you repeat, but **combining each creature's unique abilities + its element + the environment** (slamming the ground to raise dust, using the snow, spinning up tornadoes with wind, **radiating your element onto the right terrain** to trigger reactions).
2. **Bond over collection.** Small maximum team (3). Choosing your companions is a decision with narrative and strategic weight. *Connect, don't collect.*
3. **The world tells the story.** Light, accessible narrative on the surface (Zelda/HTTYD tone); the deep lore (the Tomes, their destruction) stays hidden in subtle clues for whoever explores.

1.3 Gameplay references

Temtem · Pokémon Legends Z-A · with **soulslike + character-action combat with lock-on**. Capture and bonding draw from Pokémon; combat, from action games.

2. Audience and platform

ASPECT	DECISION
Platform	**PC / Console** (gamepad and keyboard+mouse)
Audience	Creature-collector fans who want an **active gameplay experience**; action players
Tone	Zelda / *How to Train Your Dragon*: warm and accessible, with optional dark lore
Visual style	**Stylized / cel-shaded**

3. Narrative and setting

3.1 Premise (surface layer, HTTYD tone)

The protagonist lives in a village that **fears monsters**. A rival village tries to destroy their town using beasts. To defend their people, the protagonist learns to **connect with the monsters** instead of fearing them, proving that humans and beasts can **live in harmony**. The emotional arc is a change of perspective: from fear to bond.

3.2 Deep lore (hidden layer, subtle clues only)

In the past, civilization was ruled by **Eight Great Tomes** that granted elemental control. A Great Leader, fearing that humanity should not wield such power, **destroyed the Tomes**. Their essence fused with nature ("magical pollution"), giving rise to the **sentient elemental beasts** and collapsing civilization into a dystopia of ruins (**"Ancient Spots"**). The pure matter of the Tomes became **sacred Dust (Pulvis)**, scattered across the world.

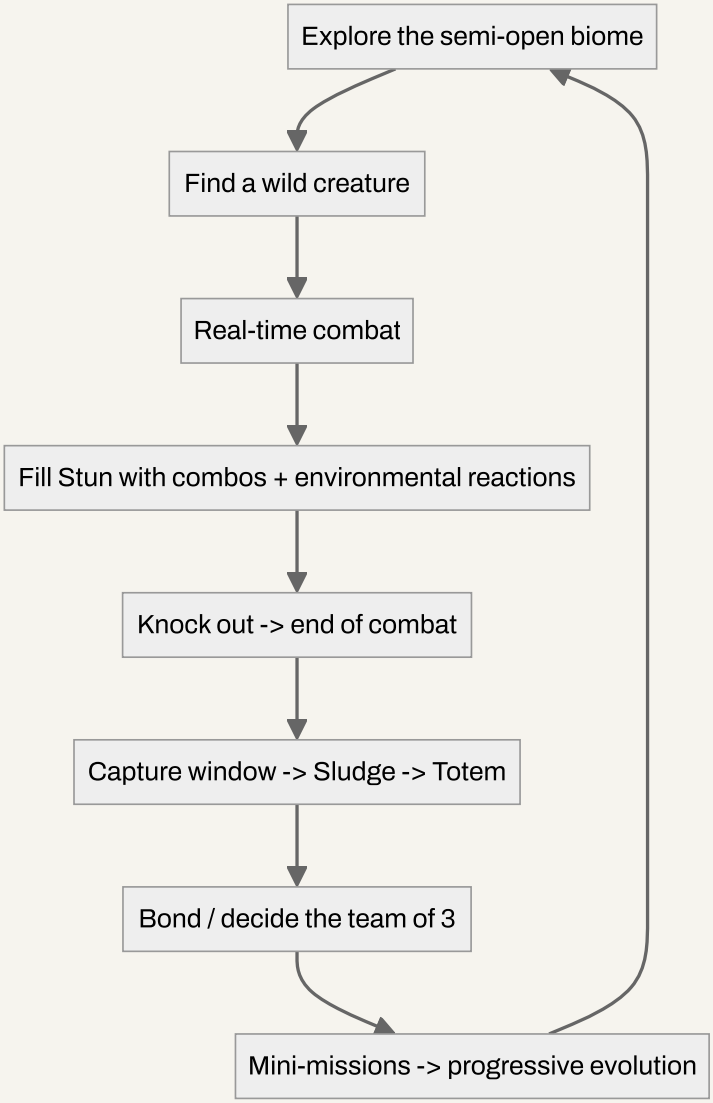
> **The game doesn't explain this directly.** Only subtle environmental clues (ruins, murals, objects).

3.3 The Dust, the Sludge and the Totems (justification for capture)

The survivors ("Scavengers" / "Tamers") gather **elemental Dust** and mix it with **water** to create a **magical sludge**. Thrown onto a weakened creature, it reacts with its essence, **hardens and crystallizes into a Totem** shaped like a simplified version of the beast. The Totem is its **vessel** until it is summoned again.

---

4. Gameplay loop (core loop)



- **Micro (second to second):** move, target (lock-on), chain basic attack + 3 abilities + jump + block, manage elemental energy, exploit the environment.
- **Meso (session):** explore the biome, find and capture creatures, advance evolution mini-missions, clear the dungeon and its boss.
- **Macro (campaign):** change the village's perception, fend off the rival village, form the bond with your team of 3.

---

5. Combat system (core of the USP)

5.1 Control and camera

- **1 active creature at a time.** You control it fully (third person).

- **Quick swap** between team members, with a **cooldown**.
- **Lock-on** to the target (action/soulslike-style camera).
- The **Tamer is NOT a target** while they have a tatemis in combat: narratively they are "untouchable" (they dodge any attempt). They only explore; the monsters fight.

5.2 Elemental energy (resource)

- **Splatoon-ink** style model: the 3 abilities consume **elemental energy**, which **slowly regenerates per second**. The **basic attack costs no energy**.
- **Blocking** speeds up regeneration.

5.3 Ability kit (template per creature)

Each creature has **3 abilities** (they cost energy), with these template roles:

1. **Mobility:** movement or stealth; it doubles as the "dodge".
2. **Flex:** a direct damage attack **or** an effect (CC, buff, AoE, debuff), depending on the species.
3. **Signature:** unique to the species; any category, or something entirely new.

Plus the **universal actions** (every creature):

- **Basic attack:** a chain with no energy cost; the backbone of combat and the base Stun generator. **The basic attack carries NO element** (neutral damage, always x1) unless a species says otherwise. *Reason: if the action you repeat most carried an element, fighting someone who counters you would go from hard to impossible. The element must be a **lever** you work with your kit, not a tax on every hit.* The exception is the **last link of the chain**, which can **burst in the species' element**: the reward for sustaining the whole chain. *(Ottorock: 4 neutral claws + a finisher that bursts in Mineral.)*
- **Jump.**
- **Knockout:** no dedicated button and **no prompt**. When Stun fills up (or health is very low) the enemy is left **weakened**, and finishing it off is **simply to keep attacking it**. The only route to the knockout is playing well (combos + reactions), not spamming a button.
- **Contextual:** only for **interacting with the world** (squashing a mushroom, grabbing and throwing an object, activating something in the environment).
- **Block / Elemental recharge:** the creature **takes on its pure elemental form**:
  - It **defends** and **recharges elemental energy faster**.
  - It **cannot attack while blocking** (committed stance: the decision has weight).
  - **Downside:** in pure form, elemental weakness is **amplified from 1.5x to 2x**. Blocking against your counter is a real risk.
  - The details (duration, mitigation) vary slightly per creature.
- **Aim (hold):** a third camera state. The camera moves **over the shoulder** with a reticle and the monster faces where it points; you can use the basic attack and abilities while aiming, **in exchange for reduced mobility**. It is what lets you aim at a **point in the world** (not just an enemy) and cast Mobility in **any direction, including vertical**.

The three camera states, all chosen by the player, and a single rule: *the attack always goes where the body is facing*; the only thing that changes is what decides it: **free** → your movement · **lock** (toggle) → the enemy · **aim** (hold) → the camera.

Reference mapping (gamepad): LS/RS/R3 move · camera · lock-on · A jump · X basic attack · B Mobility · Y contextual (interact with the world) · RB Flex · RT Signature · **LT aim (hold)** · **LB block (hold)**. On **mouse+keyboard**: aim = right click, lock = Q, block = Shift.

5.4 Stats and archetypes

A hybrid of **stats + ability/action**. The main stats (**Damage, Health, Speed**) define the creature's **archetype**, modulated by its **nature**:

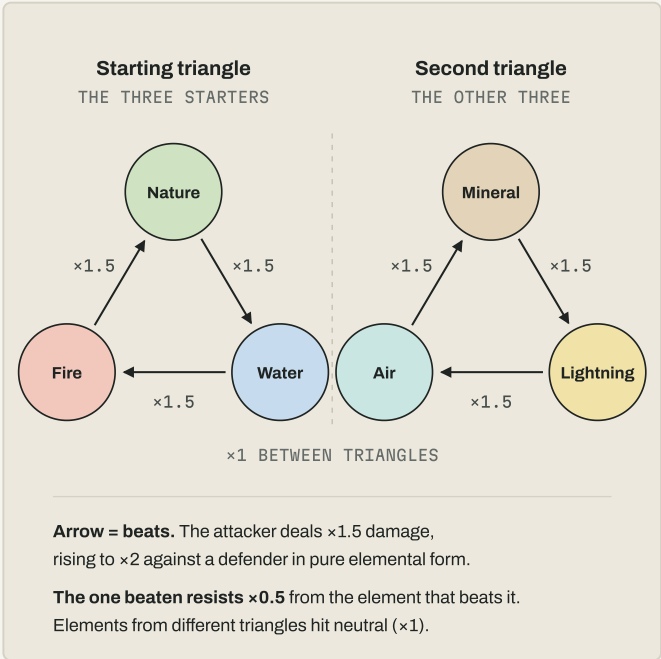
ARCHETYPE	ROLE IN ACTION COMBAT
Colossus	Takes every hit it needs to **pull off its thing**: its health is the cost of its effect. It is not a protector
Fighter	Owner of the **clean 1v1**: playing its game, it always wins. Sustained contact DPS
Executioner	**Gets in, blows up, gets out**: burst + mobility, high risk (glass cannon)
Zoner	The war of **distance**: sustained punishment at range; its zones buy it distance or an escape
Controller	**Destabilizes** (moves, immobilizes, suppresses) with **phenomena of its element turned into a kit** (species marks with their own logic, like Mantagale's tornadoes) and punishes by itself. Not through reactions: **a pure element only does damage**. The **verb** governs reactions; the **archetype** governs the kit

6. Elemental system

6.1 The 6 elements and the two layers

Six elements, split into **two rock-paper-scissors triangles**. The arrow means **"beats"**: its hit does **1.5x** damage, rising to **2x if the defender is in its pure elemental form**, and the one receiving it **resists 0.5x** from the one it beats.

> **Who carries an element and who doesn't.** The multiplier **only applies to what is imbued with an element**: the **3 abilities of the kit** and the **elemental bursts**. **Basic attacks are neutral**, so you can always deal damage even if your opponent counters you: the element decides *how much playing well is rewarded*, not *whether you can play*. Corollary for the terrain: a neutral basic attack **does not trigger reactions**; what radiates element onto the ground is the ability or the burst.



- **Within a triangle:** a rock-paper-scissors relationship (**1.5x / 0.5x**; the weakness rises to **2x** against pure elemental form). **A single weakness per element** → total readability.
- **Between triangles:** neutral (1x).
- **Starters:** one of each element of the Starting Triangle (**Nature / Water / Fire**), iconic and "marketable".

The logic of the matchups (so they read on their own):

STARTING TRIANGLE		SECOND TRIANGLE	
Nature › Water	the roots drink the water	Mineral › Lightning	rock grounds and disperses the discharge (*grounding*)
Water › Fire	puts it out	Lightning › Air	the storm rules the skies; lightning splits the air
Fire › Nature	burns it	Air › Mineral	the wind erodes the stone

> **The element is two things at once:** a **multiplier** (this section) and a **verb** that only appears **when it mixes with the terrain**. On its own, **an element only does damage**, and that is a perfectly valid option: it is the safe, immediate one, and the ×1.5 against what you beat is already its reward. The six verbs, **Fire spreads · Water drags · Nature entangles · Mineral weighs down · Lightning paralyzes · Air clouds over**, sit on **different axes and don't overlap**: they are each element's identity on the board.

> **"Mineral" identity = rock / stone / crystal** (NOT refined metal). This resolves the electrical contradiction: rock is an insulator, which is why it grounds lightning; a conductive metal would be the opposite.

6.2 Mapping to the lore (Tomes)

Nature → Tome of Nature · Water → Tome of Water · Fire → Tome of Fire · Mineral → Tome of Earth (rock/crystal) · Lightning → Tome of Electricity · Air → Tome of Wind.

6.3 Secondary element (optional)

Most creatures are **single-element**. Some, in their **final evolutionary form**, gain a **secondary element** that **does NOT change weaknesses/resistances**; it only lets them use that element in some ability (utility/flavour). **It is not mandatory:** many creatures **never unlock it** and keep **a single element**.

---

7. Environment, reactions and capture (USP)

7.1 Two complementary environmental systems

1. **Elemental reactions (the "continuous circle").** The terrain has **its own element** (volcanic rock → Fire · river → Water · **grass / tall grass** → Nature · **ore field** → Mineral · electrified stone → Lightning · air currents → Air): it is the board, and its role is to be **a third player with a history**. **All 6 elements have their own terrain on purpose**: without Air terrain, the Lightning › Air pair would be unreachable. Abilities **radiate their element on impact**, and from there come **five outcomes**:
   - **Neutral ground** → nothing: just the hit.
   - **Your own element** → **amplification**: your explosion **repeats** after a moment.
   - **An element you beat** → **your reaction**: it bursts with damage of your element and **doesn't reach you**.
   - **An element that beats you** → **the terrain's reaction**: the same explosion, but it is **its own and belongs to no side**; it reaches you too.
   - **Across triangles** → **combination**: nobody is in charge, so the damage is **neutral**, it belongs to no side either, and instead of bursting it **transforms the area** for a while.

   A pure element only does damage. Loose fire doesn't set things alight and loose lightning doesn't paralyze: **environmental effects are born only from the mix**, as in the real world. What each element brings to that mix is **a verb** (**Fire spreads · Water drags · Nature entangles · Mineral weighs down · Lightning paralyzes · Air clouds over**) and **the verb of the dominant element wins**; the other only sets what the mix is made of.

   The terrain CHARGES before reacting, and it changes when it does (see the Elemental Reactions document). An impact doesn't trigger anything: it **deposits saturation** in the patch it hits. Filling it costs **1 unit** to amplify your own element, **2** to convert neutral ground, **3** for a combination, **5** for a reaction, and once full the patch is **primed**: **you choose when to pop it**. It then bursts with a **wave that travels through it from where you hit**, and leaves **terrain of another element** behind (steam leaves Air, a blaze leaves ash/Mineral…), which **returns on its own** after a while unless the fight keeps going on top of it. So there are **fewer, much bigger events** (≈ one every 15 s, each hitting like 4 to 5 abilities), **the world changes with what the monsters do**, and aiming at the ground goes from reflex to **investment**. The effect **sticks to whoever it reaches**: inside the area it lasts, outside it decays.

   The warning is the board itself. The patch **can be seen filling up** and pulses when it is ready, so the explosion can afford to be huge without being unfair: it gives you time to get out, and the wave takes a moment to arrive because it

travels.

How much it should weigh: the damage split of a full duel is **30% basic attacks / 40% abilities / 30% terrain**. The environment is not decoration or an extra: it weighs as much as your basic attacks, and *a good combo is chaining while aiming at elemental zones*.

Examples: Water puddle + Lightning → **current**, a belt that drags whatever steps on it *(combination)* · volcanic rock/Fire + Water → **geyser** that **launches** and opens up aerial play *(Water dominates)* · Mineral vein + Fire → **lava flow**, the only zone that **advances** *(combination)*.

The 15 pairs (6 reactions + 9 combinations), the rules and the per-species exceptions are in the Elemental Reactions document.

2. **Physical / weather interactions.** *Independent of the type chart.* Slam the ground → dust cloud; snow → ice shards; strong winds → mini-tornado; water currents, etc. **It can snow or be windy without there being an "Ice/Wind type"**: weather is physics that abilities exploit. This keeps the chart simple **and** the environment very rich.

7.2 Capture (harmony as a choice)

The protagonist seeks **harmony**: the core flow **subdues, it doesn't kill**.

- The enemy has **Health** + a **visible Stun bar**, and the size of that bar is **proportional to its maximum health** (tanks absorb more stun).
- **The stun each hit adds is proportional to its damage**, multiplied by the **combo**: what fills it is hitting hard and in a row. That is why environmental reactions weigh so much in capture: they deal **real damage** (30% of the total), not a separate bonus.
- **It decays if you stop hitting**, and that is where control comes in: **CC doesn't fill the bar, it HOLDS it**. While the enemy is controlled it **cannot reduce what it has already built up**. Trapping, dragging or tying down is what stops it from emptying between hits. And the other way around: **the CC you eat costs you the capture more than your health**, because it breaks your chain. → Capture **rewards the USP** (ability + environment), not spam.
- You can try to capture at any moment, but the high odds come with the **knockout**.
- When Stun fills up (or health is very low) the enemy is left **weakened**, **with no prompt or button**: there is an **invulnerable margin** to decide, and once that margin passes, attacking it is finishing it off.
- A **short capture window** opens: you throw the **Sludge**; there is a low chance the creature **resists**. If it resists or the window ends, **it flees and disappears**.

7.3 Capture method

Sludge: it is the most distinctive and on-identity option.

7.4 Totems (physical object)

The Totem is a **physical object** the player **wears** as an accessory (bracelets, necklaces, earrings, in the style of Pokémon's Mega Stones), with the **simplified shape** of the creature it holds.

8. Creatures and progression

8.1 The trio

Three species designed in depth, **deliberately complex** to find the limits of the ability system before standardizing it. Each one uses the same elemental board in an **opposite** way:

SPECIES	ANIMAL	ELEMENT · ARCHETYPE	ITS VERB	HOW IT USES THE BOARD
Pyrecko	gecko	Fire · Zoner	**build up and detonate**	sows invisible fuel and **lights** it

SPECIES	ANIMAL	ELEMENT · ARCHETYPE	ITS VERB	HOW IT USES THE BOARD
Ottorock	otter	Mineral · Fighter	**commit and repeat**	**brings the terrain to the enemy** (portable sealed rock)
Mantagale	flying manta ray	Air · Controller	**improvise**	**brings the enemy to the terrain** (drags it across the map)

- **Strategic triangle** (born from the kits, not from the elemental chart): Pyrecko › Mantagale › Ottorock › Pyrecko.
- They cover 3 of the 5 archetypes; **Colossus and Executioner** are left for the next species.

8.2 Roster

- **Final game:** the **full type × archetype matrix = 6×5 = 30 species**, one per cell.
- Each species: **2 to 4 forms** (counting the base "baby" form).
- **Subtle rarity:** creatures with higher final stats have a **harder early phase** and **more evolutionary forms** (pseudo-legendary style).

8.3 Progressive evolution (= their "levels")

- Each species has **mid-gameplay mini-missions** to evolve.
- Evolution is **progressive**: small cumulative visual changes until the form is complete. These changes **are its "levels"**: they raise stats steadily.
- Between one form and the next there are **2 to 3 levels**.
- When evolving, some base abilities **improve** or are **replaced** by others.

9. The Tamer

- **Role:** explores the world, directs and empowers the creatures. **Does not fight directly** and is **untouchable** in fights between monsters.
- **Progression:** raising the **bond capacity** raises the **active team limit** (1 → 2 → 3). The player starts with only the starter (a gift) and must **see other creatures before being able to add a second one** → natural onboarding. It also improves **how well abilities use the environment** (Legends Arceus style).

9.1 Team philosophy: "connect, don't collect"

- **Maximum team: 3.**
- To recruit a new creature you must **release** one from the team. There is a way to **retrieve the last 3 released**.
- **Narrative justification:** the creatures boost their abilities thanks to their **bond with the Tamer**; having too many would **dilute** that bond.

10. World and structure

- **Structure: semi-open, medium-small size**, built from **biomes** tied to elements (each biome with its base element and its weather). Combat happens in a **framed arena** over a light hexagonal overlay that marks each section's predominant element.
- **Cell composition: 5 elemental / 5 neutral**, biased by the biome. The environmental layer is not a cell class but a **modifier** on top of any cell, and neutral cells **charge up** until they turn elemental. It is what **rewards a versatile team** (specializing in a group of elements, covering a whole triangle, or mixing it up) and turns the arena's mix into a **first-order balance lever**, not decoration.
- **Ancient Spots:** dungeons / points of interest with **narrative-context bosses**.
- **Economy: Dust (Pulvis)** + water = **Sludge** (capture resource).

11. Art direction

- **Style:** stylized / **cel-shaded**, warm HTTYD/Zelda tone.

12. Glossary

- **Pulvis / Dust:** pure elemental matter from the destroyed Tomes; a capture resource.
- **Sludge:** a mix of Dust + water; thrown to capture.
- **Totem:** the crystallized sludge in the shape of the creature; its vessel; worn as an accessory.
- **Tamer / Scavenger:** the player; gathers Dust and bonds with creatures.
- **Ancient Spots:** ruins of the ancient civilization; dungeons.
- **Stun:** a bar that, once full, allows knocking out and capturing.
- **Tomes:** the original Eight Great elemental books (hidden lore).